



The Lighthouse

A guide to understanding the meaning of The Lighthouse movie through myths and archetypes. <https://digit.in/jul20-45>



The art of Jung

While Jung did not think himself an artist, he created some mystical and visionary illustrations. <https://digit.in/jul20-46>

is a symbol of the negative forces in our own unconsciousness trying to defeat our consciousness or our ego. The dragon represents the evil within, and when the hero slays the dragon, what he is defeating is his own dark side. In its most essential form, the dragon represents one of the initial steps of personal development, that of overcoming counterproductive impulses.

One story goes that in the dark of the night, an angel visited four old men and took them on a tour of heaven. When returned to Earth, one of the men lost his mind after beholding such splendour, the second man dismissed the experience as a dream, the third was obsessed with the visions and constantly went about lecturing people on what it meant, and the fourth turned into a poet, writing songs about the wonders of the world. It was the fourth man that lived a happy, fulfilling and satisfying life. This story, which is detailed in *Women Who run With the Wolves* by Clarissa Pinkola Estés illustrates the optimal approach that one has to have when exploring the subconsciousness. It builds up on Jung's essay, "The Transcendent Function". When shamans or mediums go into a trance, what they are accessing is the subconscious mind. This is the function of the realms "beyond", be it dreams or fantasy worlds. It is dangerous to over aestheticize spirituality or the ego, and at the same time it is harmful to suppress it or undervalue it. Those who are not ready to access it, will be harmed by the exposure. A balance must be struck, and Jung referred to it as a "moral obligation" to express and stay true to what an individual has learned from their explorations into the subconsciousness. On a very simple level, this can be understood as the enduring morals that we can learn from fables.

SYMBOLS

Symbols are dependent on the culture, but these are often widespread enough to wide regions. The simplest example is perhaps the

symbol of the serpent, which is evil. The best story to illustrate this is the story of Adam and Eve, where the serpent tempts man with the fruit of knowledge. Everyone knows about crocodiles and their fake tears, which is a symbol for falsity. If in the beginning of a story, the strength of a hero is shown where he fights and defeats a crocodile in a river with his bare hands, on a superficial level, we are just seeing the brutish strength of the hero, but on a deeper level the story is saying that the hero has fought with and defeated falsehood.

In the Belgian comics of Asterix, the Gaulish cockerel is a symbol for courage. Almost all around the world, the eagle is a symbol for courage. In the Tolkien Legendarium, the Eagles always appear at the point when almost all hope is lost, when Gandalf is stuck in the trees with Bilbo and the dwarfs, during the battle of the five armies just before Bilbo is knocked out and when Gandalf is trapped on the top of Saruman's stronghold at Isengard. Large cats, such as the tiger or the lion also indicate courage, while ants indicate diligence. A swan is a sign of perfection, and a butterfly indicates inconstancy. A donkey is stubborn, a fox is sly, the bear or bull is strong, and the peacock is vain. In Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows, when there are white peacocks in the lawns of the Malfoy Manor, it is a sign of the vanity of the family. There is the rare exception though, where the symbols are not universal because of cultural differences. The most glaring example is the symbol of the owl. In the west, it is a symbol of wisdom, but in the Indian subcontinent, it is a symbol for foolishness.

These symbols need not all be animals, and can be objects as well. The lamp or the torch symbolises knowledge, the wind vane inconstancy, and pillars indicate stability. If a western shows a scene of a spinning wind vane, the story is saying that there are going to be some

major changes, and that the status quo is about to change.

DREAM INTERPRETATION

One of the things that psychologists can do is interpret dreams, which is a way to understand what your unconscious brain is trying to process. Dreams are like a story that your unconscious mind is telling your conscious mind. Most of the symbols and archetypes apply just as well to dreams as well, and not just stories. For example, if you dream that you are in a cage, walk out of it, are pursued by a goat, then come across a beautiful meadow with lotus ponds and rabbits, try to photograph the rabbits, and you rescue the rabbits from someone trying to kill them, it might all seem like a pretty random dream, but these dreams actually have a deeper meaning to them. The cage represents someone exerting pressure on your ambitions, or holding you back from achieving your full potential. The goat symbolises freedom, and at the same time riches and success. The rabbit is a symbol for good fortune and luck, while the lotus symbolises hope in hard times, enlightenment and personal growth. All these together perhaps illustrate struggles in professional life. Of course, a lot of these are dependent on the context of the dream, which is why it is necessary to consult with professionals on such matters. These techniques only work on those who can remember their dreams clearly, and that is actually a skill that you can improve on by maintaining a dream diary. The more you pay attention and note down your dreams, the better you get at remembering them.

There are some dreams that are very common and easy to interpret. For example, if you dream of flying, then that simply indicates a desire to escape from the struggles of daily life. Falling teeth indicates changes in life, often a sudden or drastic one such as a relationship coming to an end or a change in jobs. 